

Different Aspects of the Stage, Physical Performance and the Audience Within Hamlet

Core facts to anchor the lesson

- Hamlet belongs to Shakespeare's playing company and was written for performance around the turn of the seventeenth century, in the same period as the first Globe playhouse.
- The original Globe opened in 1599 and could hold up to about 3,000 spectators.
- The stage was wide, open, and surrounded by spectators in galleries and yard space, so actors were watched from several sides at once.

Why this matters for Hamlet

- This is a play built for visibility: entrances, reactions, spying, confrontation, and public spectacle.
- Students should think about what the audience sees, not just what the characters say.



If this were the question: **How does Shakespeare use stagecraft in Hamlet?**

EXEMPLAR OPENING

Making Thought Visible

Shakespeare uses stagecraft in Hamlet to make thought visible. He places bodies under public scrutiny, turns watching into a dramatic action, and uses entrances, concealment and performance to shape how the audience judges Hamlet, Claudius and the court.



The Physical Stage Space

What Matters About the Stage

- It was an open-air public theatre.
- Spectators and actors could see each other throughout the performance.
- The audience was not hidden in darkness; performance happened in shared light.

Effects in Hamlet

- Court scenes feel public and exposed.
- Sudden entrances matter more because everyone can see them.
- Reaction becomes crucial: a face, pause or gesture can be read by the whole theatre.

Strong idea: Hamlet is full of scenes where private feeling becomes public display.



Exemplar sentence: The open, shared stage space matters in Hamlet because even moments of apparent privacy feel exposed, making secrecy and surveillance central to the play.

The Audience as Part of the Action

Key Facts

- By 1600, London theatres could attract huge mixed audiences from across society.
- A cheap standing place in the yard could be bought for a penny.

What That Means for the Play

- Shakespeare is writing for a crowd, not a silent classroom.
- Scenes have to be theatrically clear.
- Big visual moments matter: the Ghost appearing, Polonius hidden behind the arras, Claudius reacting during the play-within-the-play, the fencing match and poisonings.

Strong Idea

The audience in Hamlet is constantly being asked to judge what it sees.

 **Exemplar sentence:** Shakespeare writes for an alert, public audience, so Hamlet repeatedly turns ideas into visible drama: appearances, reactions and sudden actions do a huge amount of the work.

Seeing, Not Seeing, and Uneven Knowledge

Crucial Stage Pattern

- Different characters do not always see the same thing.
- In Act 1, the Ghost appears to the guards and Horatio.
- In Act 3 Scene 4, the Ghost appears again, but Gertrude cannot see it.

Why This Matters

- The audience can see the Ghost.
- Gertrude cannot.
- That creates uncertainty around Hamlet's mental state without resolving it fully.

Big Point

Shakespeare uses the stage to create uneven knowledge:

Audience

knows something

One character

knows something else

Another character

misreads the moment completely



Exemplar: Shakespeare uses selective visibility in Hamlet so that the audience becomes more informed than some characters, which heightens tension and makes judgment part of the viewing experience.

Concealment, Spying and the Arras

One of the Most Stage-Dependent Moments

- In Gertrude's room, Polonius hides behind a tapestry or arras.
- Hamlet hears a cry and stabs through it, thinking the hidden figure may be Claudius.

Why It Is So Theatrical

What Students Can Say

- This is not just about rashness.
- It is about how the stage turns surveillance into danger.
- Concealment in Hamlet is never safe.

Exemplar paragraph: The arras scene shows how much Hamlet depends on physical stage business. Polonius' hidden position creates suspense because the audience knows someone is concealed, but Hamlet does not know exactly who. When Hamlet stabs through the arras, Shakespeare turns eavesdropping into sudden violence, showing how secrecy corrupts the court.

A hidden body on stage

A visible mistake

Instant violence

A shock reveal

Soliloquy and Audience Privilege

→ What Happens in Performance

Hamlet's soliloquies give the audience access to thoughts other characters do not hear. This makes the audience unusually close to him.

→ Why This Matters in the Theatre

The audience becomes a privileged witness. It hears doubt, disgust, self-criticism and indecision directly. That means spectators are not only watching Hamlet; they are also sharing his private perspective.

→ Important Effect

Audience sympathy becomes unstable. We understand Hamlet deeply, but we also watch him fail to act, lash out, and misjudge situations.

 **Exemplar sentence:** Soliloquy gives the audience privileged access to Hamlet's mind, so physical hesitation on stage is reinforced by direct insight into the thoughts that produce it.

Acting Inside the Play: Hamlet and the Players

Act 3 Scene 2 Matters Hugely

- Hamlet gives instructions to the players about delivery and gesture.
- He criticises overacting and wants speech controlled and natural. The scene includes his advice not to "*saw the air too much*" with the hand.

Why This Matters

- The play starts talking openly about acting.
- Gesture, voice and control become part of the subject.
- The audience is encouraged to think carefully about performance itself.

Big Idea

- In Hamlet, acting is not just something characters do on stage.
- Acting becomes a method for revealing truth, hiding motive, and testing guilt.

The Mousetrap: Audience Watching Audience

- Hamlet arranges a performance that echoes the murder described by the Ghost.
- He watches Claudius's face closely.
- Claudius reacts and breaks off the event.
- Watching becomes a form of pressure.
- Guilt is exposed through reaction, not confession.
- Theatre becomes a truth-test.

 **Exemplar:** By making Hamlet direct the players, Shakespeare turns stagecraft into part of the play's argument. Performance is shown as something that can expose truth rather than simply imitate it.

Exemplar paragraph (Mousetrap): The Mousetrap scene makes spectatorship itself dramatic. Shakespeare layers audiences on top of each other so that Hamlet watches Claudius, the court watches the players, and the theatre audience watches all of them. This turns performance into an instrument of exposure.

Physical Performance: Bodies, Movement and Violence

Hamlet Is a Highly Physical Role

- He follows the Ghost.
- He drags Polonius's body away.
- He leaps into Ophelia's grave in confrontation with Laertes.
- He fences in the final scene and is wounded with the poisoned rapier.

Why Physical Performance Matters

- Hamlet is not only reflective and verbal.
- He is also abrupt, impulsive and physically dangerous.
- The audience sees the contrast between still thought and explosive action.

Good Performance-Based Ideas

Distance between Hamlet and Gertrude in the closet scene

Eye contact during the Mousetrap

Sudden changes in pace

Weapon-handling in the duel

The visible collapse of bodies at the end



Exemplar sentence: Shakespeare writes Hamlet as physically unstable as well as intellectually unstable, and that contrast is central to the audience's response.

The Ending, Gendered Performance, and What to Write in an Exam

Final Scene Facts

- The last duel involves public fencing, a poisoned cup, a poisoned blade, multiple wounds and multiple deaths.
- It is fast, visible and public.
- The audience watches the court collapse in front of it.

Another Performance Fact

In Shakespeare's theatre, female roles were played by boys; women were not allowed on the English public stage until after the Restoration. That matters for Ophelia and Gertrude: gender, fragility, grief and display were all being performed through a convention the audience understood.

What to Write If This Came Up

Use 3–4 performance ideas:

01

Stage space

open, public, exposed

02

Audience knowledge

soliloquy, Ghost, spying

03

Performance within performance

the players, the Mousetrap

04

Physical action

arras, grave, duel

Exemplar mini-conclusion: Shakespeare uses the stage in Hamlet to make uncertainty visible. The audience is constantly placed in the position of watcher and judge, while physical action, concealment and performance turn the court of Elsinore into a place where seeing is dangerous and being seen is unavoidable.